

Making Points of Information / Points of Order

Points of Information:

What are they? Points of Information are short interruptions (questions or statements) raised by the opposing team and recognized by the current speaker.

When to raise them: Points of information can be raised during each of the first four (constructive) speeches, after the first minute and before the last minute (1:01-6:00) of the speeches. Generally, they take the form of a statement or question and typically do not last longer than 15-20 seconds.

General Strategy: Always be asking questions, the general strategy for questioning is as follows;

- Clarify- Ask questions to ensure you understand what the other team is saying. First, you cannot respond to arguments that you do not have on your flow, or that you do not understand. Secondly, you do not want to lose a debate by misconstruing an argument and erroneously responding to that strawman argument.
- Commit- Ask questions to make the opposing team commit to a position or fact. This serves two purposes; First, it prevents the opposing team from being vague or shifty later in the debate. Secondly, it makes it clear what their position is and allows you to potentially have a link to an argument you might make.
- Contest- Ask questions as a preempt to your case or set-up specific arguments. You can ask questions that directly oppose their point as a way to distract the team into talking about issues irrelevant to their case. In conjunction with a commitment question you may be laying a trap for your opponents that you will spring in the next speech.

Offensive Strategy: Asking questions to interrupt the flow of the opponent's speech can break confidence or fluidity of thought. Ideally, the person not speaking next should be standing to ask questions. Do not ask random or lame questions, be thoughtful and have a reason for asking the questions.

Handling POIs:

- You might decide to limit the number of POI's the opposing team can ask, "I'll take your first of three points."
- Never stop mid-sentence or mid-argument to answer a point. If necessary you can state, "I'll take your point at the end of this argument." This will help your judge stay on your point and not be interrupted.
- Answer the question or respond to the point in the least amount of words/time necessary. You should not be rude, but do not take abusive POIs. Limit follow ups
- Do not do the work of your opponent. If you think the question is irrelevant, say so. If your opponent's think it's worthwhile, let them spend their speech time making those arguments.

Points of Order:

What are they? Points of Order are interruptions raised during a Rebuttal speech in which time is paused. The judge will hear the grievance raised by the team, allow the offending team to respond and may or may not take the point under consideration. These points should only be raised in response to a brand-new argument in the rebuttal.

When to raise them: These can only be raised during the last two speeches. During rebuttals team are not allowed to raise brand new arguments, and may be challenged on those grounds.

Strategy: Try not to be too trigger happy on these points, as teams who raise multiple points of order can seem nitpicky and annoying. However, if it is abundantly clear that the opposing team has brought a new argument, you should raise the point.

Things to consider:

- Make sure you identify the argument.
- Identify what impact this argument has on the debate. Is this a game-changer?
- State why this argument would be unfair, typically if its new and raised in the rebuttal, there is no opportunity to adequately respond to it.
- Keep it short and to the point, going off on a tangent dilutes the power of a point of order.